

The Ghoul of Overdue Fines

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Fines Desk Nobody Visits

Nobody visited the fines desk on purpose.

It sat at the very back of the Labyrinth Library's ground floor, wedged between the Section of Suspiciously Damp Maps and the shelf labeled PAMPHLETS: MISCELLANEOUS (DO NOT RESHELVE ANYWHERE SENSIBLE). A hand-painted sign above the desk read OVERDUE FINES – PLEASE PAY PROMPTLY, though someone had added in smaller letters beneath it: or else, in ink that had turned a very unpleasant green.

Maya noticed the sign first. "Or else what?"

"Nobody knows," said SPARK from her shoulder. His chest panel flickered a nervous yellow. "I have reviewed seventeen days of library visitor records. No patron has approached that desk in any of them."

Natalia stood at a respectful distance and studied the desk. A brass bell sat on the counter beside a ledger that appeared to be writing in itself — faint scratching sounds, a column of numbers updating with no visible hand — and the whole area smelled powerfully of old pennies and something else. Something colder.

"It smells like when you open a freezer that's been unplugged," Alana said, taking careful notes on her tablet.

"That," SPARK said, "is the smell of a confined supernatural entity."

All three sisters looked at him.

"I am simply reporting what my sensors indicate," SPARK said, and his panel flickered again, faster. "I did not say I was comfortable about it."

The scratching from the ledger stopped. The brass bell rang once, by itself.

Then, from somewhere beneath the desk — somewhere lower than the floor should have allowed — came a sound that was part moan, part sigh, and entirely the sound of something that had been waiting for a very long time and was becoming quite impatient about it.

"FIIIIIIINES," it said. "OVERDUUUUUE FIIIIINES."

Maya leaned toward her sisters. "Is it saying 'overdue fines' in a scary voice?"

"Technically," Alana said, reviewing her audio recording, "it is using an elongated vowel technique associated with classic haunting vocalizations. The content, however, is administrative."

The moan repeated, slightly louder: "BOOOOOKS. RETURRRRRN BOOOOOKS."

SPARK retreated three inches. "I would like to note," he said quietly, "that my operational parameters do not include ghost debt collection, and I believe this is a matter for humans."

From beneath the desk, something green began to glow.

Chapter 2 — Green and Gruesome

The ghoul rose from behind the fines desk like a man who had been crouching for so long that standing up required several attempts.

He was green. Not a subtle green — not the gentle green of new leaves or the dignified green of old library chairs. He was the green of lime-flavored hard candy left in a pocket through the wash, vivid and unexpected and slightly sticky-looking. He wore what appeared to be a cardigan of the same vintage, belted at the waist with a library lanyard from which dangled seven key tags and a HELLO MY NAME IS sticker that read: PERCIVAL.

His hair stood in four directions. His eyes glowed faintly. He had excellent posture for a ghoul.

"TREMBLE," he announced, "BEFORE THE GHOUL OF OVERDUE—"

He stopped. He peered at them over the counter.

"You're not trembling."

"We're evaluating," Natalia said.

"Nobody evaluates. They run. That's how this works." He straightened his lanyard, looking put out. "I say 'tremble before me,' there's typically some running, perhaps a dropped book, a brief scream—"

"SPARK," Maya said, "could you scan him?"

SPARK rose six inches with great reluctance, extended one sensor, and immediately retreated again. "He is definitely a ghost. I am also detecting significant emotional energy consistent with frustration and — " SPARK paused. "Mild loneliness."

Percival looked offended. "I am not lonely. I am HAUNTING."

"There's a difference," Alana said, not unkindly, writing this down.

"Yes," said Percival. "Haunting is a profession."

He attempted a second entrance by ducking below the desk and rising again more dramatically, this time with his hands raised. Three fingers on his left hand had sticky notes attached to them: OVERDUE: 47 DAYS, OVERDUE: 102 DAYS, and one that simply read EXTREMELY OVERDUE with three exclamation marks and a small drawing of an upset face.

"This," he said, wagging the sticky notes, "is why I haunt. FORTY-SEVEN DAYS! The borrowing period is three weeks! Do you know what that means in fines? At the current rate of two pennies per day—"

"That's ninety-four pence," Alana said.

Percival deflated slightly. "Yes. It is. And nobody cares. Nobody comes to the fines desk. They just — " he waved a green hand — "keep the books."

He sounded, underneath the glowing eyes and the green, genuinely upset about this.

"Sit down," Maya said. "Tell us everything."

Chapter 3 — The Wail of Late Returns

Percival did not, technically, sit. He perched on the edge of the fines desk in a way that suggested sitting was something he had done in a previous life and still remembered fondly.

"It started," he said, "with the Fenwick family."

"What did the Fenwick family do?" Natalia asked.

"They borrowed 'A Complete History of Competitive Snail Racing' in September 1987 and never brought it back." Percival's green glow flickered with the intensity of old grievance. "Never. It has been thirty-nine years. That book is, as far as I can determine, still somewhere in the Fenwick household, possibly being used as a doorstop."

"That is very long overdue," Alana said.

"The fine is currently five hundred and sixty-two pounds and forty pence," Percival said, with the specific energy of someone who had calculated this many times. "Not that anyone intends to pay it. Or even acknowledges its existence." He pulled the ledger toward him and gestured at it. "This is my record of every overdue book in the labyrinth. Every single one. Do you know how many there are?"

"How many?" Maya asked.

"Three hundred and twelve."

There was a short silence.

"Three hundred and twelve overdue books," Natalia said. "That's — "

"A significant failure of civic library responsibility, yes." Percival crossed his arms. His sticky notes rustled. "I have tried everything. I haunted the main reading room for three weeks in 2019. People simply put on headphones. I sent moaning through the ventilation system — the head librarian thought it was the boiler. I rearranged the due-date stamps to spell out PLEASE RETURN YOUR BOOKS and nobody read it because apparently nobody reads the stamped dates."

"Why does it matter so much to you?" Natalia asked. It was not an unkind question. She had learned to ask the real question directly.

Percival was quiet for a moment. He looked down at his ledger. His green glow softened from vivid to something closer to the color of a night-light.

"Because books belong with readers," he said, and his voice had changed completely — no more elongated vowels, no dramatic reverb. Just a tired, sincere thing that had been true for a very long time. "A book sitting in someone's hall closet, unread, for thirty-nine years is a book that hasn't been read for thirty-nine years. That seems like a waste."

SPARK's panel went quietly amber.

"All right," said Natalia. "We're going to help you."

Percival looked up. "You're not going to run?"

"We never run," Maya said. "We problem-solve."

Chapter 4 — SPARK's Ghost Protocol

SPARK was, by his own assessment, a highly capable analytical assistant with seventeen documented skill sets, an extensive operational history, and a calm, methodical approach to unusual situations.

He was also, it turned out, not entirely comfortable with ghouls at close range.

"I am perfectly fine," he said, hovering at a distance of approximately four feet from Percival while Maya and Natalia spoke with him. His panel was cycling through colors in a pattern Alana had come to recognize as: I am not perfectly fine but I would prefer not to discuss it.

"SPARK," Alana said quietly, "I need your sensor readings on his ledger."

"Yes. Certainly. I will approach the ledger." SPARK moved two inches closer to the desk, then two inches back. "I am gathering preliminary data from here."

"The ledger is at the desk. You are not at the desk."

"I can extrapolate."

Percival noticed. He turned from his conversation with Maya and studied SPARK with the expression of someone encountering a small, anxious toaster. "Is your robot frightened of me?"

"He is not a robot," Alana said. "He is an AI companion. And he is processing."

"I am not frightened," SPARK said, at a volume that suggested he was. "I am recalibrating my proximity sensors in response to novel supernatural electromagnetic interference."

"He's frightened of me," Percival said, and something in his voice was enormously, unexpectedly pleased. "An

actual robot is frightened of me. After thirty years of people not even noticing I exist!"

"I notice you," SPARK said, offended. "I am simply maintaining a precautionary distance from an entity whose exact spectral frequency I have not yet — "

Percival reached one green hand toward SPARK's panel.

SPARK shot backward three feet, emitting a sound that was not in his documentation.

"HA," said Percival, very loudly, which woke three pigeons from somewhere in the rafters and knocked a small stack of PLEASE BE QUIET IN THE LIBRARY pamphlets off the fines desk. He looked at the pamphlets. He looked at the pigeons. He looked at SPARK, still retreating.

Then he started to laugh — a genuine laugh, startled out of him, surprised and warm and entirely unlike any haunting sound.

"I haven't laughed in years," he said.

"We could tell," Maya said. "It sounded rusty."

"It was," he agreed, still smiling. "Shall we start over? I am Percival. I haunt the fines desk. I am — apparently — less terrifying than I intended."

SPARK, from a safe distance, straightened his sensors and said, with as much dignity as he could recover: "I was not frightened. I was startled. These are different states."

Nobody pointed out that he was still hovering behind Natalia.

Chapter 5 — Percy's Tragic Backstory

"It happened," Percival said, "on a Tuesday."

He had come around to the reader side of the fines desk — a significant gesture, he explained, because ghosts of overdue fines traditionally stayed on the administrative side — and sat on an upturned returns crate while the sisters arranged themselves on the floor. SPARK hovered at what he had privately designated as a Comfortable and Entirely Confident Distance.

"Tuesdays," Alana observed, "are statistically the day most things in literature go wrong."

"Mine certainly did." Percival smoothed a wrinkle from his green cardigan that had been there for several decades and would not be leaving. "I was a reader. A very dedicated reader. I came to this library every week from 1978 to 1991, which I calculate at six hundred and seventy-eight visits."

"That is dedicated," Natalia agreed.

"I read everything. Adventure, history, science, cookery — though I was never any good at cookery. I read the pamphlets. I read the card catalogue for pleasure." He paused. "I realize that last one sounds unusual."

"We read the card catalogue too," Maya said.

Percival brightened. "Then you understand. In any case. In the autumn of 1991, I found a book. A remarkable book. A book I could not put down — had never been able to put down, in fact, across three separate borrowing periods." He looked at his hands, where the sticky notes still fluttered. "I was on page two hundred and eighty-seven. The final chapter. The very last chapter, forty-three pages from the end."

"And?" Natalia said.

"And I was called away from the reading room before I could finish it." He said this with the precise, sustained grief of someone who has rehearsed the sentence many times without it becoming less painful. "I left the book on the reading table. I intended to be back in ten minutes." He looked up. "I was not back in ten minutes."

"What happened?" Maya asked, very gently.

Percival considered this. "I became a fine," he said. "Somewhere between leaving the table and never returning to it. I don't entirely understand the metaphysics. But the book was eventually reshelfed, and I was — here. At the fines desk. Where overdue things go."

The library was very quiet.

"You've been here since 1991?" Natalia said.

"Thirty-five years." He adjusted his HELLO MY NAME IS sticker, which read PERCIVAL in handwriting that had been done with care. "I have kept very thorough records in the interim."

SPARK, who had been listening from his distance, moved closer without noticing he was doing it.

"What was the book?" he asked.

Percival's glow softened. "That," he said, "is the question."

Chapter 6 — The Book Nobody Finished

The search took two hours, which was fast for the Labyrinth Library, where finding things sometimes took considerably longer due to the shelves' well-documented habit of rearranging themselves when nobody was looking directly at them.

Percival had not forgotten the title. He had not forgotten anything about the book — the color of the cover (dark blue, slightly worn at the top right corner), the weight of it (heavier than it looked, which he had always taken as a good sign), the author's name (D.L. Vane), and the title in silver letters: *The Phantom of Footnote Hall*.

"A phantom story," Maya said. "You were reading a ghost story when you became a ghost."

"The irony has not been lost on me in thirty-five years," Percival said.

SPARK cross-referenced D.L. Vane and *The Phantom of Footnote Hall* against the library's current catalogue. It appeared in the system as SHELVED — FICTION — GHOST AND GOTHIC — THIRD FLOOR EAST, with a borrowing history that showed it had been taken out six times since 1991, by six different readers. Every one of them had returned it.

Nobody had renewed it.

"They all brought it back?" Natalia said.

"Without exception," SPARK confirmed. "The most recent return was four months ago. Borrower note reads: 'Good but never quite finished it — something always comes up around page 287.'"

The three sisters exchanged a look.

"It's stuck," Alana said. "The ending is stuck."

"Because nobody has finished it," Natalia said slowly, "since you."

Percival stood very still beside the catalogue terminal. His glow had gone the quiet color of a lamp left on in an empty room. "I had not considered that possibility. I thought — I assumed the problem was me. That I was the unfinished thing."

"Maybe it's both," Maya said. "Maybe you and the book are unfinished together."

He looked at her. "You think if someone finishes the book — "

"I think we find out," Natalia said. "But first we have to find it."

Third Floor East was easier to navigate when the shelves cooperated, and today they seemed inclined to cooperate — possibly because SPARK was broadcasting what Alana measured as a sustained, high-pitched frequency that she suspected was the AI equivalent of nervousness but which seemed, incidentally, to discourage shelf-wandering.

The book was exactly where the catalogue said: dark blue, worn at the top right corner, heavier than it looked.

Maya pulled it down. On the inside front cover, in a borrower's pencil note long since supposed to be erased: *Chapter twenty-six is the one that matters. I never got there. — P.*

"That's your handwriting," Natalia said.

"Yes," Percival said softly, reading it over her shoulder. "I wrote that on my third borrowing. I was warning my

future self." He smiled, a little. "I was not expecting to take quite so long to arrive."

Chapter 7 — The Scaring Business

Before anyone opened the book, Percival had one request.

"Let me show you my techniques," he said. "My haunting techniques. I have spent thirty-five years developing them and I would like at least one proper audience before I potentially stop being a ghost."

Maya looked at her sisters. Her sisters looked at her. There was a silent conversation of the kind only siblings conduct, which concluded with Natalia saying, "All right. Five minutes."

Percival clapped his hands together, which produced no sound at all, which he did not seem to notice. He stepped back to the area behind the fines desk that he clearly thought of as his stage.

"Technique one," he announced. "The Classic Moan."

He moaned. It was, objectively, an impressive moan — resonant, slightly echoing, with a mournful quality that spoke of decades of practice. Then he looked at them expectantly.

"Very good," Alana said, noting something on her tablet.

"Nobody ran," Percival observed.

"We don't run," Maya said. "We've mentioned this."

"Right. Technique two." He reached beneath the counter and produced a length of chain. "The Rattling of Chains." He rattled it. The chain went clink clink clink. "I should clarify," he said, over the clinking, "that these are library book-return chains. For securing the returns box. I borrowed them from the loading dock."

"Did you return them?" Natalia asked.

Percival stopped rattling. "They're — I have them right here."

"But did you log the borrowing?"

A pause. He looked at the chains. He looked at his ledger. "This is mortifying," he said.

"Technique three," Alana said, helpfully redirecting.

He brightened. "The Sudden Appearance." He ducked below the desk. There was a short wait. Then he popped up again from a completely different angle with both hands raised and his eyes glowing at full power, which was quite impressive.

"Oh!" said Maya, who had genuinely not seen where he went.

Percival looked delighted. "Was that alarming?"

"Mildly surprising," she said. "In a fun way."

"I'll take it." He settled back on his returns crate with the pleased air of someone who has received their first review in thirty-five years and it was acceptable. "I have seventeen more techniques. Number seven involves the ventilation system and a recording I made of myself saying 'WHERE ARE THE BOOKS' and it goes on for six minutes."

"We believe you," Natalia said.

"The problem," Alana said carefully, putting down her tablet, "is not the techniques. The techniques are fine. The problem is the goal. What do you actually want people to do when you scare them?"

Percival opened his mouth. Closed it.

"Return the books," he said, at last, as if hearing it clearly for the first time.

"Right," said Alana. "And does being scared make people want to return things? Or does it make people want to avoid the fines desk entirely?"

Percival thought about this for a long moment.

"Ah," he said.

Chapter 8 — A Deal With the Ghoul

It was Natalia who proposed the Gentle Reminder Program, in the practical, direct way she proposed most things: by writing it on a piece of paper and sliding it across the fines desk to Percival.

He read it. He read it again. His green glow shifted through several uncertain colors.

GENTLE REMINDER PROGRAM (Proposed by N., A., M. & SPARK)

1. No more moaning at patron desks. 2. No more rattling chains in the ventilation system. 3. No more stern, glowing appearances in the periodicals section. 4. Replace with: friendly, helpful reminders about due dates. 5. Possibly: small notes. Possibly: SPARK broadcasts a gentle ping to readers with approaching due dates. 6. Possibly: you have a name tag that does not say PERCIVAL in a threatening font.

"My font isn't threatening," Percival said.

"Your name tag glows green in the dark and vibrates slightly when you're upset," Maya said. "The font is the least of it."

He considered point four. "What counts as 'friendly'?"

"Not making the air temperature drop when you appear," Alana said. "That is a start."

"I cannot entirely control the temperature drop. It is a natural ghost phenomenon."

"We can work around it," SPARK said, having conducted a full Internet search on spectral thermal regulation that he did not want to discuss further because it had been a very strange forty minutes. "Warmer ambient lighting in the fines area will counteract the effect. Readers will simply feel they have passed through a cold spot, which they will attribute to the ventilation."

Percival studied the paper. His sticky-note fingers moved slightly.

"What do I get out of this arrangement?" he asked.

"The books come back," Natalia said. "Your three hundred and twelve books. If patrons receive friendly reminders instead of terrifying ones, they are more likely to return them."

"That is — " He paused. "That is actually what I want."

"I know," she said.

He was quiet for a while. Outside the labyrinth's high windows, the afternoon light had gone golden. Somewhere in the stacks, a cart rumbled along its rail. Ordinary library sounds.

"There is a second condition," Alana said, and something in her voice made Maya look over. "For the Gentle Reminder Program to begin, we finish the book first."

Percival looked at *The Phantom of Footnote Hall*, which Maya had set on the counter between them.

"You think that matters," he said.

"Yes," Alana said simply.

Percival looked at the book for a long moment. Then he nodded.

"I would like to hear the ending," he said. "I have been wondering about it for thirty-five years."

"Then sit down," said Maya, picking up the book. "We'll read it to you."

Chapter 9 — The Gentle Reminder Program (In Practice)

They did not read the ending immediately. They read from the beginning.

Not because they had to — the book had been read by six other people since 1991, and the story was not confused or incomplete in the way some borrowed stories get when too many readers leave their fingerprints on the plot. They read from the beginning because Percival had not heard any of it in thirty-five years, and because Maya had

a theory about stories that she had never quite stated aloud but lived by: that a story you haven't finished deserves to be approached from the start, the way you return to a conversation you had to leave in the middle.

They took turns reading. SPARK projected the page numbers softly above the text so Percival could follow along from his crate.

While they read — spreading the work across the afternoon, chapter by chapter, taking breaks for tea that the library's small corner kitchen produced and biscuits from Alana's bag — Natalia set up the first test of the Gentle Reminder Program.

She borrowed Percival's ledger. She found the twelve books with the most recent due dates — books borrowed in the last two months that had not yet crossed into overdue territory — and beside each entry she wrote a small message in green ink (Percival had insisted on green; it was the one design element they allowed him):

Hello! Just a friendly note from the fines desk: this book is due on [date]. We hope you're enjoying it. Return when ready — the library misses it!

"The library misses it," Percival repeated, looking over her shoulder. "That's — that's quite good. It implies the book has feelings."

"Books do have feelings," Maya said, without looking up from chapter seventeen.

"Technically that is a metaphor," SPARK said.

"SPARK," Maya said.

"I am recording it as a successful metaphor," SPARK said, and projected a small heart beside the note.

They attached the notes to small cards which SPARK slipped under the relevant borrower records with a delivery mechanism he described as "straightforward routing" and which Alana suspected involved passing through walls, because SPARK's propulsors were not long-range. Neither of them mentioned this. Some operational questions were better left unasked.

"How long before we see returns?" Percival asked.

"Give it a week," Natalia said.

Three days later, six of the twelve books came back. Four of the six had notes attached: *thank you for the reminder! Didn't realize it was so soon!* and *this was great, do you have anything else like it?* and, from a small person whose handwriting was very round, *here is your book sorry i kept it so long.*

Percival held that last note for a long time.

"Nobody has ever apologized to me before," he said.

"We know," said Natalia.

Chapter 10 — The Book Is Found (Chapter 26)

They reached page two hundred and eighty-seven on a Thursday evening, when the library was quiet and the last few patrons had wandered out and the labyrinth's familiar night-sounds had begun: the settling of shelves, the whisper of dust settling, the very occasional distant sound of a book deciding it preferred a different shelf and making the short journey there.

Percival sat very still.

"This is the page," he said.

"I know," said Maya, who was reading. "I can tell."

She kept reading. Chapter twenty-five concluded with the hero of *The Phantom of Footnote Hall* standing at the door of the forgotten archive — the room where the phantom had hidden for forty years among books it had once loved — and making a choice about what to do with someone who had stayed too long in one place because they were afraid of what came next.

Alana, who had been listening with her tablet closed for the first time all day, looked up when Maya paused.

"Go on," said Natalia softly.

Maya turned to chapter twenty-six.

She read it aloud, slowly, the way you read something that has been waiting a long time. The phantom in the story was not frightening by chapter twenty-six. It was just tired, and very fond of the books it had lived among, and not entirely sure what came next, and it turned out that what came next was quite simple: it only needed someone to tell it, honestly, that there was one.

The library was very quiet when Maya reached the last page.

Percival was glowing — but differently. Not the vivid, agitated green of the fines desk. Something steadier. Warmer. The color of a reading lamp in a room where good things were happening.

"It ends well," he said. He did not make it a question. He had known, perhaps, since page one.

"It ends well," Maya confirmed. She closed the book.

Nobody said anything for a moment. SPARK, who had listened to the entire thing and had also — though he did not announce this — quietly cross-referenced 847 literary analyses of how stories about haunting typically resolved, dimmed his display to a considerate level.

Then Percival made a sound that took them all a moment to identify.

He was crying. Quietly, with great dignity, in the way of someone who has not cried in thirty-five years and finds that it is both more and less difficult than they remembered.

"Thank you," he said.

"Thank you for the story," Natalia said.

She meant it. She had found, in the last forty-three pages, a sentence she had already read three times: *"The bravest thing a person can do in a library is ask for what they need."* She had written it in the small notebook she carried for thoughts that needed to be written before they escaped.

She did not tell Percival this yet. But she would.

Chapter 11 — The Last Fine

What happened to Percival after chapter twenty-six was finished was not dramatic in the theatrical sense.

There was no boom. No flash. No dissolving into sparkles with a cheerful sound effect, which Alana had privately predicted as a forty percent probability based on narrative convention.

What happened was quieter and, Maya later said, much better.

His green glow shifted — gradually, the way a lamp shifts when you turn the dimmer — from the vivid, worried green of an unresolved thing to something closer to gold. Warm and steady and not particularly anxious. His sticky notes detached from his fingers one by one and floated down to the ledger, where they settled into the pages as if they'd always been bookmarks.

The EXTREMELY OVERDUE note with the three exclamation marks landed on a page near the back.

Percival looked at his hands — unsticky-noted, for the first time in decades.

"Oh," he said.

"Are you all right?" Natalia asked.

"I think I am." He turned his hands over, studying them with the expression of someone discovering they can uncurl their fists after a very long time of holding them tight. "I feel — less." He searched for the word. "Less accumulated."

"Less overdue," Alana suggested.

"Yes. Exactly." He stood from the returns crate and moved to the fines desk and opened the ledger to the back, where the last entry had been — the EXTREMELY OVERDUE notice that had belonged to **The Phantom of Footnote Hall**, borrowed October 1991, never returned, fine accumulated to seventeen pounds and forty-two pence.

The entry was still there. But where the fine amount had been, the number now read: SETTLED.

No one had written that. It had simply resolved itself, the way accounts settle when the last thing owed has been received.

"Thirty-five years," Percival said.

"What will you do now?" Maya asked. She was genuinely curious, in the warm way she was curious about things she cared about.

Percival considered the question very carefully. He looked at the fines desk, which he had haunted for thirty-five years. He looked at the three hundred and twelve returns that had been trickling in since the Gentle Reminder Program began — forty-one books back in the last week alone, the library shelves slowly and steadily filling with things that had been missing.

"I thought," he said, "I might stay."

"As a ghost?" Natalia said.

"As a librarian." He straightened his cardigan, which continued to be very green. "An unofficial one. Spectral. But the books know me. The shelves know me. I have been here thirty-five years and I know this library better than anyone alive." He paused. "And I am, it turns out, quite good at friendly reminders."

SPARK's panel went a warm, decisive amber.

"I will log that as an approved operational arrangement," SPARK said.

Chapter 12 — The Honorary Librarian

The official title, printed on a laminated card that Alana produced from the library's visitor services office using the patron badge printer that nobody had known was in there, read:

PERCIVAL — HONORARY SPECTRAL LIBRARIAN Fines, Returns & Friendly Reminders (Please do not run)

The note at the bottom was Natalia's idea. Percival had asked for it specifically.

They fixed it to the fines desk counter with a small stand Alana fashioned from a bent return-cart clip, and for the first time in thirty-five years, the fines desk had something on it that invited people toward it rather than convincing them to take the long route around.

Three hundred and twelve books had been outstanding when the Gentle Reminder Program began. By the end of the following month, the number was one hundred and ninety-four. By the month after that, it was sixty-seven. The notes came back with the books — thank-you notes, sorry-I-kept-it-so-long notes, a very long note from the Fenwick family who had received a particularly warm reminder about *A Complete History of Competitive Snail*

Racing* and who had not only found it (behind the radiator in the upstairs hallway, apparently having rolled there) but had also read it and written a full paragraph about what they had enjoyed.

Percival kept every note in a folder labeled CORRESPONDENCE, which he stored under the fines desk beside his ledger.

He haunted the library still — but differently. He appeared at the ends of aisles with friendly expressions and a pointed look at the due-date slip, which most readers found charming once they had been warned. He moved returns carts when they were blocking the reading tables. He occasionally rearranged the shelves when SPARK's analysis suggested a reorganization would help — though he always left a note saying what he had moved and why, because thirty-five years of maintaining meticulous records had given him an instinct for documentation.

When readers arrived looking lost, he would appear beside them in his warm gold glow and say, in a voice that no longer boomed or elongated its vowels: "Can I help you find something?"

Most of them said yes.

Maya, Natalia, and Alana came back to visit on a Tuesday — Tuesdays, after all, could go differently than expected. SPARK buzzed a greeting to Percival's green cardigan, which was as close as he would come to admitting fondness for a former spectral entity.

"Three hundred and twelve books," Natalia said. "How many are left?"

"Eleven," Percival said, with satisfaction. "And four of those are with readers who send regular progress updates." He showed her the most recent note: *almost done, returning Thursday, it was exactly what I needed.* "I believe they are genuinely enjoying them. I have not hurried them."

"Good," said Natalia.

She sat at the reading table nearest the fines desk — the one where the lantern light was warmest — and opened her notebook to the page where she had written: *The bravest thing a person can do in a library is ask for what they need.*

Beneath it, in new ink, she added: *The second bravest thing is staying long enough to help others find theirs.*

Percival read it over her shoulder, the way helpful ghosts do.

"That's quite good," he said.

"It is," she agreed.

Outside, the labyrinth continued its quiet, endless work: books moving, readers coming, stories beginning and ending and being passed along to the next person who needed them.

THE END